

TOPIC 16 - BOUNDARY, ROUTES AND NON-LINEAR CHRONOLOGY

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/13

c. 200 BCE-300 CE: a connected frontier world, not one invasion wave.

Bactria/Oxus -> Hindu Kush -> Kabul-Gandhara-Taxila -> Punjab-Mathura -> Ganga routes.

Lower Indus and western ports linked caravan traffic to Iran, the Roman world and Indian Ocean.

Indo-Greek, Shaka, Pahlava and Kushana powers overlapped with Shunga, Kanva and Satavahana states.

WRITE: group -> ruler/source -> region -> mechanism -> impact -> limit.

TOPIC 16 - SOURCE LADDER AND CONFIDENCE CONTROL

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/13

COINS: names, portraits, titles, scripts, deities, metals, dies and overstrikes.

INSCRIPTIONS: dates/eras, donors, officials, genealogy and royal claims.

ARCHAEOLOGY/ART: sites, workshops, routes, monasteries and material context.

CHINESE/CLASSICAL TEXTS: Yuezhi movement, Bactria and trade; translated outsider categories.

BUDDHIST/LATER TRADITIONS: Menander and Kanishka memories; genre and redaction limits.

CORE CAUTION: coin circulation != political border; style != ethnicity; praise != neutral report.

TOPIC 16 - INDO-GREEKS: DYNASTIES, COINS AND MENANDER

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/13

Demetrius: early 2nd-century BCE crossing south of Hindu Kush; route and extent debated.

Several houses and rulers were concurrent; no secure continuous Bactria-to-Pataliputra empire.

Bilingual portrait coins: Greek/Prakrit legends, Greek/Kharoshthi scripts, epithets and monograms.

Menander/Milinda: coin-secure ruler associated with Sagala; wide circulation is not a frontier.

Milindapanha: layered dialogue with Nagasena, not a verbatim court record or proof of mass conversion.

Heliodorus: Antialcidas' envoy, Bhagavata, Garuda/Vasudeva pillar at Besnagar; one person's affiliation.

TOPIC 16 - SHAKAS AND WESTERN KSHATRAPAS

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/13

Maues/Moga and Azes: north-western coin-inscription sequences; Azes-era association disputed.

Rajuvula: Mathura Kshatrapa; early 1st-century CE capture of Sagala from Strato III.

Kshatrapa/Mahakshatrapa: flexible ranks; delegated rule could become dynastic sovereignty.

Nahapana/Kshaharata: coins and Ushavadata donations; Gautamiputra overstrikes mark displacement.

Chashtana-Rudradaman/Kardamaka: durable western line; cross-link, do not absorb into Satavahana history.

Junagadh, Shaka year 72: Sudarshana repair + genealogy + conquest + Sanskrit prashasti; rhetoric remains.

TOPIC 16 - PAHLAVAS / INDO-PARTHIANS

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/13

Gondophares/Guduhvara anchors a distinct Indo-Parthian layer in Afghanistan-Gandhara.

Coins and the dated Takht-i-Bahi context are firmer than later narrative traditions.

Inherited Greek titles and coin forms show adaptation, not dynastic identity with Indo-Greeks.

The Acts of Thomas association has historical interest but cannot authenticate every itinerary or event.

Do not erase Pahlavas as an empty bridge between Shakas and Kushanas.

TOPIC 16 - YUEZHI MOVEMENT AND KUSHANA RULER SEQUENCE

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/13

Chinese histories: Yuezhi displaced west, dominate Bactria; Guishuang/Kushana branch consolidates.

Kujula Kadphises: early unification and south-Hindu-Kush expansion; chronology remains approximate.

Vima Takto / Soter Megas: identification historically debated; Rabatak reshaped genealogy.

Vima Kadphises: major gold/copper issues and Shiva/Oesho-associated imagery.

Kanishka I: major modern chronology c. 127 CE; do not automatically equate with Shaka era 78 CE.

Huvishka and Vasudeva I: later high-Kushana phases; names and icons do not prove exclusive creed.

TOPIC 16 - MULTI-CENTRED EMPIRE AND TITLES

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/13

Major centres: Bactria, Kapisa/Begram, Purushapura, Taxila and Mathura.

Rabatak names eastern cities, but royal claims require corroboration for depth of control.

Direct rule, subordinate authority, influence and coin circulation must be mapped separately.

shaonano shao = king of kings; devaputra = son of god; exalted sovereignty across idioms.

Satrapas, local rulers, cities, guilds and religious establishments mediated governance.

No single capital or uniform district system fits every reign and region.

TOPIC 16 - TRADE, CUSTOMS, CITIES AND MONETISATION

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/13

Silk Routes were changing corridors, not one road owned by Kanishka.

Kushana nodes linked China/Tarim, Bactria, Gandhara, north India, Iran and maritime circuits.

States taxed/protected segments; merchants, caravans, ports, guilds and monasteries made exchange work.

Gold and copper Kushana issues show high-value and everyday monetary capacity in selected circuits.

Roman contact is one bullion/trade factor, not the sole cause of Kushana gold or universal prosperity.

Mathura, Taxila, Purushapura and Begram were differentiated caravan, craft and consumption centres.

TOPIC 16 - MILITARY MOBILITY AND STIRRUP CAUTION

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/13

Horses, saddles, bridles, bows, armour and riding dress moved through repeated contact and adaptation.
Tunics, trousers and boots are contact-zone visual markers, not ethnic certificates.
Cavalry suited the Bactria-Gandhara-plain corridors and became prominent in royal imagery.
Coin/statue images show representation more securely than unit organisation or battlefield doctrine.
True-stirrup dating is contested: do not confuse toe loops/supports with paired iron stirrups.
SAFE VERDICT: stronger cavalry influence-yes; sole Kushana invention of the stirrup-unproven.

TOPIC 16 - RELIGION, MAHAYANA AND PLURAL PATRONAGE

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/13

Kanishka: major Buddhist patron in coins, inscriptions, monuments and later memory.

Council in Kashmir and Sarvastivada compilation survive chiefly in later traditions; details are contested.

Mahayana developed gradually; no ruler single-handedly founded it.

Kanishka/Huvishka coins include Buddha, Oesho, Nana, Miir/Mithra, Mao, Atash and other deities.

Coin deity = public iconography/constituency strategy; not automatic personal conversion.

Transmission depended on monks, translators, merchants, monasteries and routes as well as rulers.

TOPIC 16 - GANDHARA, MATHURA AND MULTILINGUAL CULTURE

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/13

Gandhara: schist/stucco, modelled anatomy, wavy hair and drapery in a layered Buddhist idiom.

Mathura: red sandstone, older local forms, Buddhist-Jaina-Brahmanical-royal range.

Neither school was pure, isolated or merely a copy; Buddha-image priority remains debated.

Indo-Greek coins: Greek + Prakrit, Greek + Kharoshthi; Kushana usage includes Bactrian in Greek script.

Rudradaman's Junagadh: major courtly Sanskrit inscription; Prakrit and other languages continued.

Calendar, astronomy, clothing and science claims must separate selective exchange from total invention.

TOPIC 16 - SOCIAL INTEGRATION, SYNTHESIS AND DECLINE

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/13

Integration worked through service, marriage, language, donations, guilds, cults and workshop life.
Brahmanical labels such as fallen-kshatriya classifications are normative arguments, not census data.
Replace one-way Indianisation with reciprocal but unequal adaptation and cosmopolitan synthesis.
Indo-Greek fragmentation, regional Shaka longevity and Kushana contraction followed different clocks.
Kushana decline: dynastic division + Sasanian pressure + regional successors + changing fiscal/routes.
Political rupture coexisted with continued coins, art, Buddhist transmission and regional institutions.

TOPIC 16 - UPSC TRAPS, PYQ ROUTE AND QUALIFIED VERDICT

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 13/13

2019 GS-I: separate Greco-Bactrian visual form from Central Asian patronage, costume and route context.

Prelims traps: ruler-dynasty, title-office, coin-border, deity-conversion, era-accession, script-language.

10 marks: 2-3 evidence units; 15 marks: 4-6; 20 marks: 6-8 plus source criticism.

PARAGRAPH: claim -> named coin/inscription/site/text/ruler -> analysis -> qualification.

VERDICT: contacts produced frontier states, monetised networks and plural cultures without uniform control.

Never attribute every innovation solely to invasion or every adaptation to passive assimilation.